





MAKING MEMORIES (Clockwise from top) Meditating in the serene surroundings of Ensa Gompa; one of the rooms at Lchang Nang Retreat; enjoying a Central Asian meal at an old farmhouse

famed for its hot sulphur springs and supposed curative properties. Past Panamik, I crossed a bridge on the river and made my way to the remote Ensa Gompa—with fading frescoes and jolly novices—the kind that's not really on any tourist map.

On the way back, I made a detour to the Sumur sand dunes. This pristine spot with not a soul in sight is in stark contrast to the dunes at Hunder where Bactrian camels—a remnant of Nubra's past as a prominent pit stop on the Silk Route—give joyrides to tourists in the droves. Let's not forget that just past Siachen, across the Karakoram Pass lies Yarkand in the Xinjiang autonomous region of China.

While Lchang Nang offers many curated experiences, ranging from stargazing expeditions to private yoga sessions focused on breathing, the one that stood out for me was a simple meal quickly rustled up one evening by womenfolk back from working their fields at a centuries-old farmhouse with a stone hearth. Nubra is something of a Shangri-La, but you must know where to look. ■

Amit Dixit

You'll need to get a permit and pay an environmental fee of Rs 400 per person at www.lahdclehpermit.in to enter Nubra. At the checkpoint, you will also have to show you've acclimatised in Leh for at least two nights before travelling further, for which the boarding pass of your flight into Leh should work. Cottages at Lchang Nang Retreat start at Rs 25,500 plus taxes per night (www.lchangnang.com).